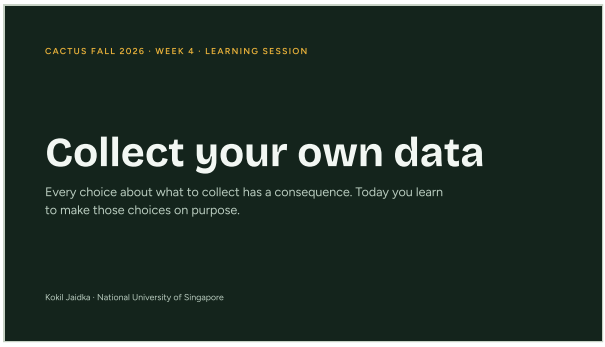
CACTUS Week 4: Collect Your Own Data



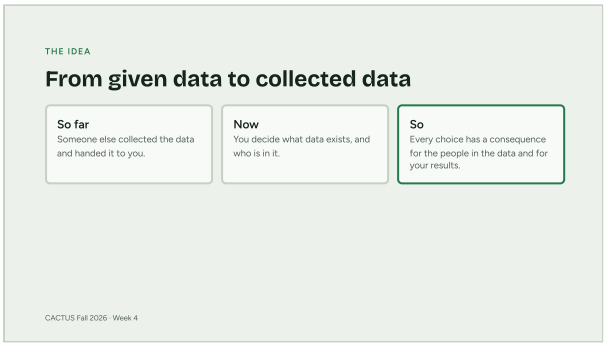
Slide 1

TIME 1 min (0:00)

SAY Welcome back. So far you analyzed data you were given. Today you decide what data exists, which is a bigger responsibility.

DO Welcome people. Post the course site and the access guide links. Ask who has their data (an export), and who does not have any yet (hands or chat). Say there is a saved example for anyone without data, and that those students should talk to the facilitators.

NOTE This is a 60-minute session. The collecting happens in the coding session.



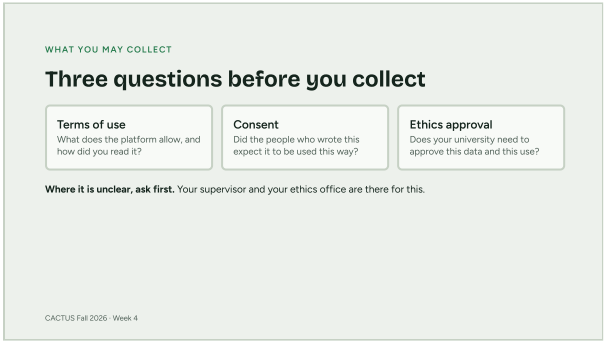
Slide 2

TIME 4 min (0:01)

SAY Someone else collected your data in Weeks 2 and 3. Now you choose what exists and who is in it. Every choice has a consequence for the people and for your results.

DO Read the three cards. Ask: what is one thing you could collect that you probably should not?

WATCH FOR Time. This is a short framing slide.



Slide 3

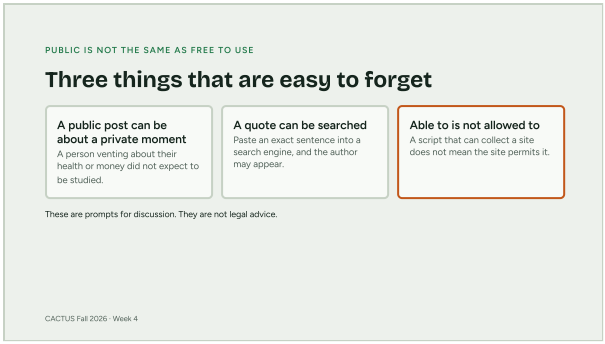
TIME 5 min (0:05)

SAY Three questions before you collect. What do the terms allow? Would the people who wrote this expect this use? Does your university need to approve it?

DO Read the cards. Say plainly: you are expected to find out the answers for your own data, and to ask when unsure. Give the contact for your university's ethics office if you have it.

IF ASKED about a specific rule say you do not know, do not guess, and ask the ethics office. Never give legal advice.

WATCH FOR People who want a yes or no. Say: the answer depends on the platform and your project, so we practice asking the right questions.



Slide 4

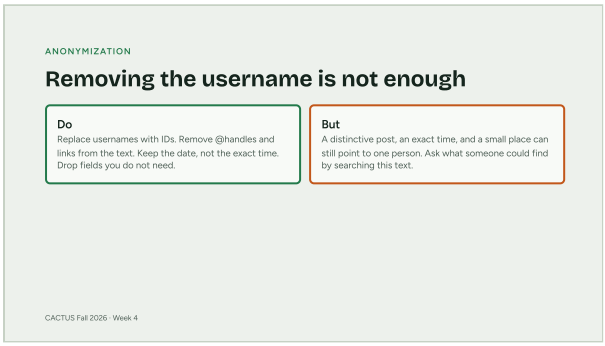
TIME 5 min (0:10)

SAY Public does not mean free to use. A public post can still be about a private moment. An exact quote can be searched. And being able to collect something is not permission.

DO Read the three cards. For each, give a short invented example, not a real person. Remind everyone these are discussion prompts and not legal advice.

IF ASKED about a real case do not name or look up real people. Keep it general.

WATCH FOR Moralizing. The goal is to build a habit of asking, not to scare people.



Slide 5

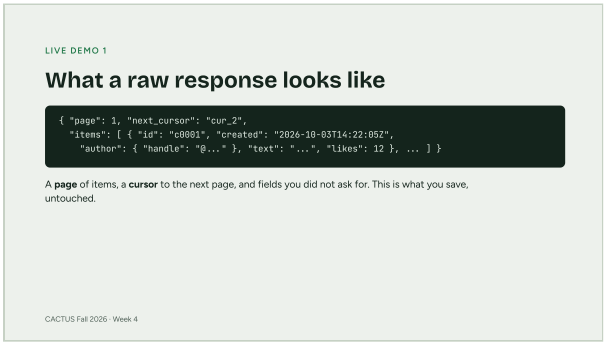
TIME 6 min (0:15)

SAY Removing the username is not enough. Do replace usernames with IDs, remove handles and links from the text, keep the date and not the exact time, and drop fields you do not need. But a distinctive post, an exact time, and a small place can still point to one person.

DO Ask the room: what could someone find by pasting this sentence into a search engine? Let them think for a moment. Say the practice page has a re-identification meter.

IF ASKED whether anonymization is possible it lowers risk, it does not remove it, which is why we also keep data private.

WATCH FOR People who think a checkmark means safe.



Slide 6

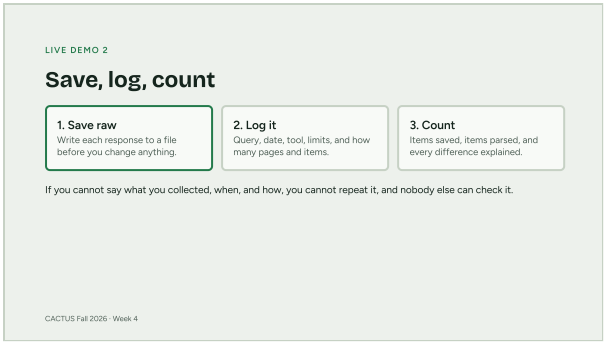
TIME 8 min (0:21 to 0:29)

DO (demo) Open page_001.json from the saved example (data/week04/sample/ in the repo) and show it on screen. A facilitator can instead make one live request if they want to. Point at the items list, the cursor for the next page, and the fields you did not ask for.

SAY This is the thing you save, untouched. Everything else you do comes after.

DO Ask the room: which fields here identify a person? (Handle, display name, profile link, text.) Do not read out any real person's content. If the real response contains real people's posts, show it without reading names aloud, or use the invented sample from the notebook.

WATCH FOR If you make a live request, do not show keys on screen. Hide the key before sharing your screen.



Slide 7

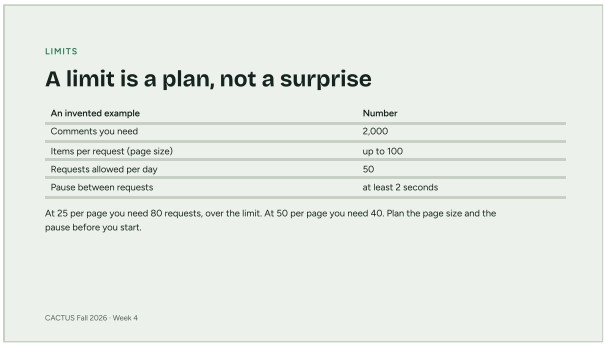
TIME 8 min (0:29 to 0:37)

DO (live demo) Run the collection stub from the notebook warm-up on the invented sample. Show the files appear in the raw folder, and the log file. Then count: items saved against items parsed.

SAY Save raw first, log it, then count. If the counts differ, you have to be able to say why.

DO Ask the room to predict the number of rows after parsing. Say that in the coding session the sample has a surprise in it.

WATCH FOR Do not reveal the duplicates and deleted items in the sample. Students find them in Exercise 2.



Slide 8

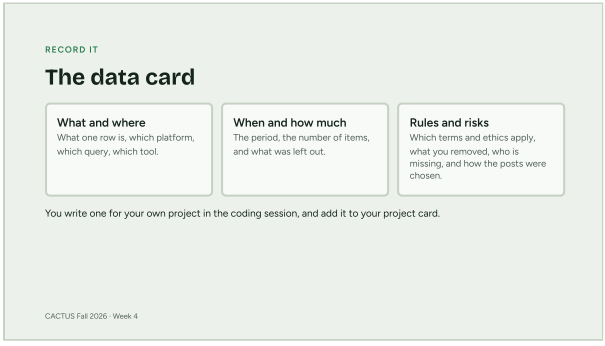
TIME 5 min (0:37 to 0:42)

SAY A limit is a plan. Here is an invented example: 2,000 comments, 100 per page, 50 requests per day, 2 seconds between requests. At 25 per page you would need 80 requests, over the limit. At 50 per page you need 40.

DO Ask the room to work out the requests at page size 100. Then say: your real limits are in the platform's documentation. Check them. The numbers here are not any platform's real limits.

IF ASKED about getting more quota say it depends on the platform, and that is a question for the access guide.

WATCH FOR People who skip the pause. Say the pause protects you from being blocked.



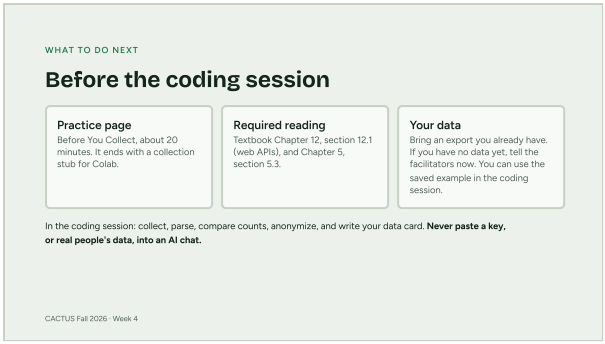
Slide 9

TIME 4 min (0:42 to 0:46)

SAY A data card is a short record of what you collected and how. What and where, when and how much, which rules and risks. Include how the posts were chosen: all of them, a random sample, the platform's top-ranked ones, or a keyword search. A keyword search decides what is in your data, and who is missing. You write one for your own project in the coding session.

DO Read the three cards. Say it takes ten minutes and it is the first thing a supervisor or a reviewer will ask for.

SAY If you cannot say what you collected, when, and how, nobody can check it, including you in six months.



Slide 10

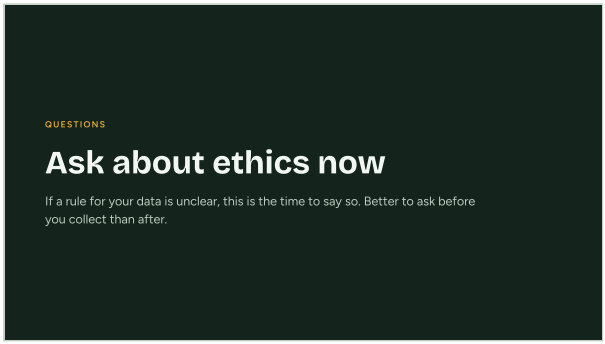
TIME 5 min (0:46 to 0:51)

SAY Before the coding session: the practice page (about 20 minutes), the required reading (textbook Chapter 12 section 12.1 and Chapter 5 section 5.3), and have your data, or know how you will get it.

DO Post the practice page link, the course site link, and the access guide. Say clearly: bring an export you already have. If you have no data yet, use the saved example, and talk to the facilitators now so you have data before Week 6.

SAY In the coding session there is no lecture. Collect, parse, compare counts, anonymize, write your data card.

SAY (important) never paste a key, or real people's data, into an AI chat, a notebook, or a repository.



Slide 11

TIME 9 min (0:51 to 1:00)

SAY This is the time for questions, especially about ethics. If a rule for your data is unclear, say so now. It is much better to ask before you collect than after.

DO Take questions. If you do not know the answer, say so and write it down for the ethics office or Kokil. Do not guess about rules.

CLOSE Thank everyone. Remind anyone without data to talk to the facilitators, and about the access clinic.
